

Today, on the auspicious occasion of the 49th anniversary of our Independence Day, I convey my heartiest greetings to you. It is with your support and determination that India today is able to hold its head high in the comity of nations. It is for the fifth time that I am addressing you once again today during the five-year tenure of my Government. I deem it my duty to place before you an account of our performance and also to give you an indication of the picture I have formed in my mind for the future.

You know the conditions which prevailed in the country when the Government took over in 1991. The country was on the brink of disintegration, economic crisis, and near bankruptcy. Since then, with your help, your cooperation, and blessings, this Government has been able to achieve progress in a number of spheres. And above all, the world has reposed faith today in India's political stability, harmony, and economic well-being. Today nobody has any doubt about this. This is a great achievement of all of us and I want to congratulate you on this.

We had to work hard to achieve this. There were troubles, disturbances in many parts of the country for many years which have been brought under control by us. You are all aware of this. In Punjab, Assam, Bodoland, etc., there were disturbances, some of these were there for over many years, and they have been brought under control. You have also been aware of this situation. I need not go into details. I feel today's biggest problem, which, in fact, is no problem, is an artificially created one.

There is unrest in Jammu and Kashmir for the past four-five years. You have only yesterday witnessed the outcome of violence and terrorism which is being exported to our country. The incident is an example of how cruelly and brutally the terrorists are working and creating panic. I want to tell you that this is not really a problem at all. The truth is that Jammu and Kashmir is an integral part of India and nobody can take it away or snatch it away from us. Now, the point is that Pakistan has illegally occupied certain areas and Pakistan has no right or claim over that from any point of view. But being a neighbouring country, it is possible for it to send its people equipped with arms and funds to create disturbance. Nobody can clearly understand why they have been doing this. Today the entire world knows the motive behind the actions of Pakistan in Kashmir. Now, they have understood who are responsible for whatever is happening here in Jammu & Kashmir and the responsibility rests squarely on Pakistan.

From the beginning we are ready for any discussion and sit together and discuss but that they should stop all these mischief and actions. Then we will sit together and we are always ready to resolve any differences. We will always be ready for it, we will always respond. We only say, stop anti-India actions.

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When the present Prime Minister of Pakistan took over, I wrote a letter the same day inviting her to have a dialogue with us on the basis of the Shimla Agreement. Before this we had given them

six proposals which are called non-papers. They are called non-papers because what we want to say, however, has no authoritative value and whatever was written was worth considering — outstanding issues which had to be sorted out between them and us. We did not get any reply from them. Instead they gave us two papers with impossible conditions. We say that there should be no preconditions for talks. But they put such conditions which can never be acceptable to us. We cannot even touch them, let alone consider them. What this implies is that they really did not want to talk. They expressed their unwillingness by putting impossible conditions in these papers. That is where the situation rests today.

If they stop exporting terrorism and get out of the habit of raising the Kashmir issue in various international fora, because they have not achieved any tangible results and nobody has taken notice of Pakistan raising the issue, then we can go ahead and hold discussions. And we can develop very good relations. Just as we have good relations with other neighbouring countries and with other countries of the world. This is in their hands. I would only say that they should think about it. They have tried the same things for years and they have seen the results. Not only this has not yielded results, but distances have increased; we have to reduce these distances. This is the only way to resolve the problems and we are ready for it.

Of late, a number of new problems, new issues are being raised in the country. There was a time when in the name of religion and on the basis of caste the people were provoked, their sentiments were exploited, and efforts were made to take political advantage of it, perhaps reaping immediate benefits. I thought that with the development programmes that we started in the country on such a large scale, this tendency will perhaps get diminished. It did to some extent. But now it looks that there are renewed attempts to exploit religion. I would like to submit that efforts to mix religion and politics will never succeed. This way both religion and politics will lose their meaning and also their purpose. Let us all think it over again and address ourselves to the basic questions of bread and butter, on issues facing our country today, the national issues, political issues, and try to find their solutions, instead of going back to religion. Religion and politics have their own respective places.

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Now the issue of Personal Law has come up. It has been raised as an issue. At the time when the Constitution was framed, it was raised in the Constituent Assembly and at that time Dr. Ambedkar, who has the credit of drafting our Constitution, himself had said that we only want to have the right. It doesn't mean that we will make a present uniform code. It cannot be so. There are many a problem. It doesn't mean that we don't respect our Constitution. We always abide by our Constitution. But the kind of difficulties we face today and our experience of resolving the difficulties during the last forty years teaches us that the most important thing is how we decide our priorities, how to identify our thrust areas. We have to see on which problems we have to focus. We should have a clear view before ourselves.

I understand that different communities have their own Personal Laws. Hindus, Muslims, Parsis, and Christians, all have their own Laws. It is not very easy to have one uniform law for all of them. Uniform means dressing up all in one way like in a uniform. It will mean imposing the Personal Law of one community on the other or the vice versa. Or remove both of them and bring a third one and implement, then only it can be made uniform otherwise it cannot be. I want to say that today it is very difficult and we should not get into this. We will see it later, today we cannot say what will happen in future. But this is not such a task which can be taken up today and moreover, we cannot introduce a law against the wishes of a community which will be affected by this law. We have a very old maxim:

\$\$\text{"Yadyapi Suddham Lokaviruddham;}"\$\$

\$\$\text{"Na Acharaniyam Na Karaniyam."}\$\$

> *(Even if something is pure and good, it should not be practiced or carried out if it goes against the will/welfare of the people.)*

Therefore, it should not be implemented if it is against the wishes of the people affected by it. This is an old teaching from the times immemorial. Therefore, I want to reiterate that we will not interfere in this matter at all, at present. Not only today, I do not think that we would be able to implement it for a long time to come. I do not think it proper to dwell upon this issue today.

Apart from Kashmir, we are trying to bring peace in other areas of the country such as North-East and I feel that people are already fed up with violence in these areas. Talks are on and they are contemplating that they should join the mainstream. I hope that this will be resolved very soon.

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Now, I will briefly dwell on the economic aspect about which you are well aware. Sometimes attempts are made to mislead people. In 1991, we were on the brink of bankruptcy. We thought that in 1991 the country would go totally bankrupt. We had no money, not even to import essential items like kerosene. Foreign reserves were at the rock bottom and we managed the situation with great difficulty. Today, we can say that what we have been able to accomplish in the last four years is a great achievement. While we did not even have the reserves of Rs. 2,500 crore in 1991, today we have Rs. 60,000 crore of foreign exchange reserves. This enables us to import anything without any difficulty.

We have freed the industry from the shackles of permits and licences because there was no scope of progress under controls. Today, barring a few industries related to defence, etc., we do not have licence controls on the rest of them. They are running smoothly. You will be happy to hear that all this has happened within three years. In the first year, no one wanted to come here

nor we were in a position to invite them. Initially we had to make a lot of efforts to convince people that we have changed our policies but nobody believed us. All this progress which we witness today has actually been made in the past two and a half to three years only, not more than that. Now I will give you some data that will make you happy: Rs. 68,000 crore have been invested here and another Rs. 25,000 crore in our public sector. On the whole, the country is making rapid strides in the industrial sector.

Now, I will dwell upon what we are doing with our funds. We have launched several schemes and programmes for poverty alleviation for the benefit of the poor of this country. You can see that we could not do anything in 1991 because we had no money. We made some headway in 1992 and whatever schemes we launched in that year, are for the welfare of the poor.

On 1st January, 1992, I inaugurated the Revamped Public Distribution System in Barmer District of Rajasthan. This meant that we focussed on those 1,700–1,800 blocks located in hilly, desert or tribal areas which are very poor and prepared a definite plan to ensure supply of food and other essentials to those areas.

At the same time we started another programme on the 1st January, 1992. It was for rural artisans. They included artisans such as carpenters, goldsmiths, ironsmiths. Their tools are very old and obsolete and therefore, their productivity has been decreasing and they were unable to compete with others. We, therefore, have launched a very big programme to improve their tools and provide them with modern tools. About two and a half lakh of our artisans have received tools and another two lakh will be provided during the current year. This means that the tools with four-and-a-half to five lakh artisans in rural areas would be upgraded and modernised. This would increase their productivity and they will not be required to move out of their villages and go to towns and cities. It is our estimate that many people who go to towns have now settled down in villages where their productivity as also the income is increasing.

In 1993, we started a scheme for empowerment of women — the Mahila Samriddhi Yojana. Along with it, we began the Employment Assurance Scheme under which at least 100 days of employment is being provided to people in every village at times when there is no agricultural work or there is a drought with a view to preventing the migration of people to urban areas. I want to tell you that this scheme is working smoothly. It is being run in areas wherever there is a need for it. It has had a very good impact. So we began in 1992, and in 1993 we started two-three schemes including Prime Minister's Rozgar Yojana for the youth. In 1993, the scheme was confined to cities only. During 1994, it was extended to villages also. This means that whatever resources the Government has were utilised for the poor.

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We have invested a lot of money in the poverty alleviation programmes and we are doing so since 1992. All our programmes are to remove poverty. We have not given any money to the

rich and on the other hand, we have made them to invest their money in the industry. Whatever money we saved from their investment, we spent on the poor of the country. This year we have taken up several poverty alleviation programmes and you can see the qualitative difference.

The foremost amongst the new programmes is the mid-day meal programme which is being introduced in the primary schools all over the country. Earlier, this scheme existed in some states and in other states it took off but stopped mid-way after sometime. Now, we have decided that since we have enough food-grains, a stock of three crore tonnes, therefore, we will take food-grains from this stock and make an attempt to give nutritious diet to our children. This scheme is being launched from today.

All these four schemes are being launched from today. I have already told you about these schemes. I just want to conclude by saying that all such programmes have been initiated by the Centre for the first time.

Another scheme is meant for the poor, particularly those who are below the poverty line. Among these, in case of death of the head of the family or the breadearner, the family will get an assistance of Rs. 5,000/- in case of natural death. But if the death is due to accident, the family will get Rs. 10,000/-. This scheme too is being taken up by the Central Government for the first time.

Our maternity benefit programme also is a similar programme which aims at helping pregnant women, those women who are poor, who don't have anybody to look after them during delivery or are too poor to spend on medicines. This programme is intended to give financial assistance to them.

And the most important measure, and this is a new measure. Have you ever heard that the poorest of the poor would also have life insurance? Probably not. Simply because it was not possible earlier for anyone but for those rich, those who could pay for it. No poor ever imagine that insurance was something meant for them. Central Government is starting a scheme for providing life insurance. Two forms of insurance are envisaged in this programme. For the individual, who could pay the premium, they could go in for it, which is very cheap. They are to pay only half the premium and in their case the other half is paid by the Central and State Governments.

The experience has shown that it is possible to provide insurance cover on the basis of group insurance. We are taking the entire village or a block as a unit. The insurance cover is not for an individual. If the people of a village or a block go in for insurance, the benefit will automatically be available to anyone in case of death to be entitled to a sum of Rs. 5,000/- as insurance cover. Now this programme is a novel concept in providing cover to the poorest of the poor. Central Government is trying, for the first time, that the benefits of insurance reach the poorest of the poor, and not just the rich who can afford to pay all the insurance premiums.

We have also launched a programme about child labour especially to reduce the incidence of children working under compulsion in hazardous work. A programme was started to abolish child labour in a big way from industries which are injurious to health and are hazardous. For the past one year, the work on this programme is being carried out and the progress is very good.

I want to inform you that we are consistently working for the upliftment of the poor for the last four years. Every year something new is being added. But it is not a one-time programme; it is a continuous process. None of these programmes, whether started in 1991, 1992, or during this year, is going to be discontinued within a few years. Whenever a programme is started by the Central Government, it is a continuing programme. There is no doubt about it. I want to ensure you that we have done this after adequate deliberations. Those programmes which could not be taken up during 1991, were started in 1992, and those which could not be launched in 1992, were started in 1993. Thus we are taking up these programmes after taking into account resource availability and all other related aspects.

That is why the mid-day meal programme for children being launched from today is not being implemented throughout the country all at once. We do not have sufficient resources for that. We want to complete it within three years. This year we have selected about 2,500 blocks where poorest of poor live. We have started this programme first for the poor children. We want to cover the whole country within two years. But, God willing, we may complete the programme within two years instead of three years.

What I mean to say is that we have started only as much as we can achieve after making thorough calculations. We are initiating and implementing these programmes with due deliberations. Benefits of these programmes to the people are no secret. They are for all to see.

Exports have to play an important role in our economic progress. Earlier we were exporting raw material like rice, paddy, or tea, and not exporting finished goods at all. Our exports now consist of machinery, of what is called value-added products. They are competing with other products which are produced here. They are competing in the world markets. Our exports have increased. In the past year we have recorded a 20% increase. It is not a small thing for a developing country like India; it is a big achievement.

Some have raised the slogan against the investment made in the country saying that it has been made for the big people. I want to tell you that it is totally wrong. 80 percent of the investment has been made in the basic infrastructural sectors like power, petroleum, steel, which are of great importance to us. Hence, it is totally wrong to think that it is aimed at satisfying the cravings of the consumers or giving a boost to consumerism. I would like to tell you that it is not so, and we have data to prove it.

You will be surprised to know that we are the second largest producer of milk in the world. U.S.A. is the only country which produces more than we do. I was also happy to learn about this fact. It was difficult to imagine that our country could make such strides in the area of milk production within three-four years. But it has happened in fact.

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We have increased the prices of the farmers' produce and made arrangements for the fertiliser for them. Still farmers complain and ask for more. Fertiliser prices have gone up; we are considering it. After a dialogue with them, if something is required, we will do that. There should be no worry on that score. What our farmers have achieved is no less than a miracle. I congratulate them for this. I want to tell them that they should forge ahead in the same way and rest assured that from our side we will provide all the help they require; there should be no doubt about it.

All these programmes that I have placed before you for the past year are aimed at accelerating social progress and social welfare. We are taking up these programmes on a very large scale. We are spending Rs. 18,000/- crore on these programmes for rural development and social services as against Rs. 8,000/- crore in 1991. So this money that we are providing is meant to reach every village, to provide relief to the rural people, to give them more employment, and to create new opportunities for them so that the standard of their life improves. It is a big programme. I will not say whatever is needed to be done has been done. Nobody will be able to say that. This is a continuous process. And whatever funds we have, whatever funds we can save from industrialisation will be spent on this vast programme of removal of poverty. We are going to make this a country-wide programme. More and more money will be spent on this programme. This is our considered policy.

Earlier too I have said as much and I repeat again because efforts are being made to create misunderstandings in this regard. Nobody should think that this programme which I have just placed before you is the only programme and we have no programme other than this. We have to be vigilant particularly on our borders. We will not allow any laxity to come in the way of our research programmes and continue them.

Our institutes of higher education like IITs etc. have produced scholars who have no difficulty in getting jobs anywhere in the world. People come here to recruit personnel from these institutes. These institutes we want to further strengthen through a programme of modernisation because the equipment, etc., in these institutes have become obsolete. This we are doing and one bigger programme is in fact our biggest programme, is one of schools. We want that illiteracy should be eradicated from the country. It has been said that by the end of this century India will have the largest number of illiterates in the world. We feel ashamed to visualise such a scenario.

Therefore, we have decided and I have declared that in the Ninth Five Year Plan, six percent of the GDP will be spent on education. In fact, this was said 30 years ago in the Government's policy statement. But because of various reasons, we could not do much in this regard during the last 30 years. Today we can. Today we are in a position to do so starting with the Ninth Five Year Plan, to undertake this on a large scale all over the country to spend this much of money on the spread of education. This is our national policy.

There may be leakages in some of the employment programmes. In some respects some mistakes might have been made. It is always better to try to correct one's mistakes. It is no good to find flaws to spread pessimism and despair. It is our duty to cooperate in making this programme a success. I look forward to your support and request also.

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As for the future, you know there are a large number of developing countries in the world. Many among them don't want to remain developing forever. These countries are trying to get a developed status. A number of such countries lie in our neighbourhood, in East Asia and South-East Asia. Many of them have resolved to get out of the developing stage and achieve developed status within the next 25 years.

Just think what India is lacking in. We don't have shortage of resources, we have no shortage of skilled manpower, and we have no dearth of determination. That is why I think that it is possible for our country to make its place among the developed countries of the world in the next 25–30 years. We have the potential. But the only condition is that we should not waste our energies in unnecessary things and devote ourselves wholeheartedly to realise our objective. Once we concentrate on our objective, success will be ours.

I can only say this much about our future: that once such a big country as ours and all of us together devote our energies to forge ahead with determination like other countries have done, we too will realise our objective and there will be no shortfall in our achievement. I see it clearly, I look into the future, and there is no country in the world which will disagree to what I say. Every country has recognised our potential. And they are ready to come to us to invest more and more in our country. Many are ready to enter into partnership with us to play any role, to make any contribution that is necessary for the development of our country.

Today, we have no dearth of anything. What we need is determination and concentration to achieve our goal. I want to tell you that if we have these two, we would have no problem. The programmes that I announced recently will be implemented from today. We want to start the Indira Mahila Yojana Programme on 20th of this month, the Birthday of late Shri Rajiv Gandhi. This programme had been formulated by him, he had put in a lot of effort in this, therefore, we want to launch this programme on his Birthday. We have identified 200 blocks in which this

programme for women only would be taken up. This would be a very intensive programme. This will begin on 20th of this month.

There are some other things that I would like to tell you. This is a historic place. It was from this place that Bahadur Shah Zafar had started the fight for Independence against the British government. This is the place where the INA associates of Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose, who fought along with him, were interned and tried. You may recall that it was in this trial that Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, who had not fought any court case for many years, had come forward to defend them. Of such historic importance is this place. We want to convert this place, where the trial was held, into an exhibition, a museum. This museum will start on 2nd October, 1995, the 125th anniversary of Mahatma Gandhi, to enable people to see and appreciate the work done by these patriots.

We are also going to celebrate the birth centenary of Netaji as also of Shri V.K. Krishna Menon who among many others worked hard from abroad to create an atmosphere favourable for our freedom. We want to celebrate his birth centenary also. So, we have a programme of action to celebrate the birth centenaries of these great leaders. The Museum, which will come up within the Red Fort precincts, would remind coming generations of these brave souls and great patriots. This is my fervent hope. These programmes are reminiscent of our past and our history.

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I would also like to speak to you about our Foreign Policy in short. During the past four years, our Foreign Policy has been very successful. Earlier too, during the times of Panditji, it was very successful. It was given further boost by Indiraji, and Rajivji took it forward. We have maintained the trend; in fact, it has gone a step forward in the sense that the Cold War is now over. A new atmosphere has been created in the world with the end of the Cold War. In this atmosphere it is both easy and difficult to maintain friendly relations because now there is no element of confrontation. We have to establish cordial relations with all, at the same time we have to fully safeguard our national interest. There can be no compromise in this regard.

The task is a bit difficult, however, in the last four years we have been performing it successfully. We have further improved our relations with friendly countries. We have also improved our relations with countries with whom our relations were not so good. Today, I am able to tell you that we have good relations with all countries. We are getting their cooperation and sympathy. We have sensitised them about Kashmir and other problems. They understand and appreciate our point of view regarding our policies vis-a-vis these problems.

Such good relations we have come to have with them. This augurs well for our progress which will face fewer impediments in the circumstances. There might be hard competition in the field of trade. Today it can be observed that many countries are having mild collisions with one another.

The collision is not severe but has created tension. We have to find a way out, but while doing so, we have to avoid tension and should not fall a prey to tension. It is like walking on the razor's edge. We are doing it and we will continue to do so.

I want to assure you that India's foreign policy will fully safeguard the national interest. At the same time, in the changing world scenario, we will play our role properly.

I have no doubt about what I have said. I have taken much of your time. It was however necessary to give you these details. You might have known about many of them. You might have heard about some of the schemes. But when additions are made each year, a comprehensive picture will have to be seen. So it was my duty to tell you in brief of what we achieved during the past four years. I have done this.

As I stand before you for the fifth time, I would like to say only this: that you make your own assessment of this Government on the basis of these facts. I have no doubt that taking an overall view, the achievements of this Government will be appreciated and all the people of the country will give us their blessings. I have told you in brief whatever I wanted to say. The rest is up to you. I have nothing more to add.

Now I am thankful to you for listening to me. Now I invite all of you to join me in raising the national slogan "Jai Hind" three times.

****Jai Hind! Jai Hind! Jai Hind!****

****Thank you.****